OLYMPIAS

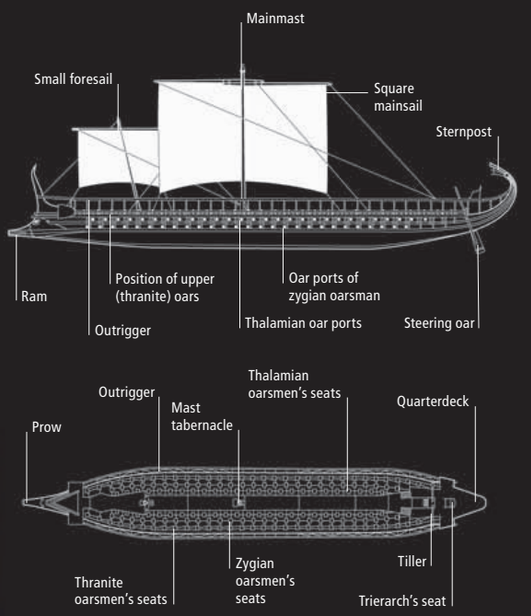
NO ORIGINAL EXAMPLE of a trireme, the key warship of Ancient Greece, has survived from antiquity. *Olympias*, built at Piraeus, Athens, between 1985 and 1987, is a scrupulous reconstruction based on the best available historical evidence. It did well in sea trials, confirming that a galley with three tiers of oars could perform impressively in action.

A GREEK TRIREME was a lightweight, shallow-draft vessel some 115 ft (35 m) long and less than 20 ft (6 m) wide. Although it cruised under sail, it was propelled in battle by 170 oarsmen in three tiers: 62 thranites highest, 54 zygians in the middle, and 54 thalamians at the bottom. With 30 other men completing the crew, including soldiers and archers, it was a crowded vessel. There was no room for carrying more than basic supplies and insufficient space for the whole crew to sleep on board. The trireme was capable under oar of speeds in excess of eight knots and highly maneuverable.

In sea trials *Olympias* was turned about at high speed in two-and-a-half times its own length. A fast-maneuvering trireme did not provide a stable platform for its fighting men—marine hoplites had to learn to throw their spears while sitting down. Even when its hull was smashed by an enemy ram, a trireme would not actually sink, as its wreckage would float.

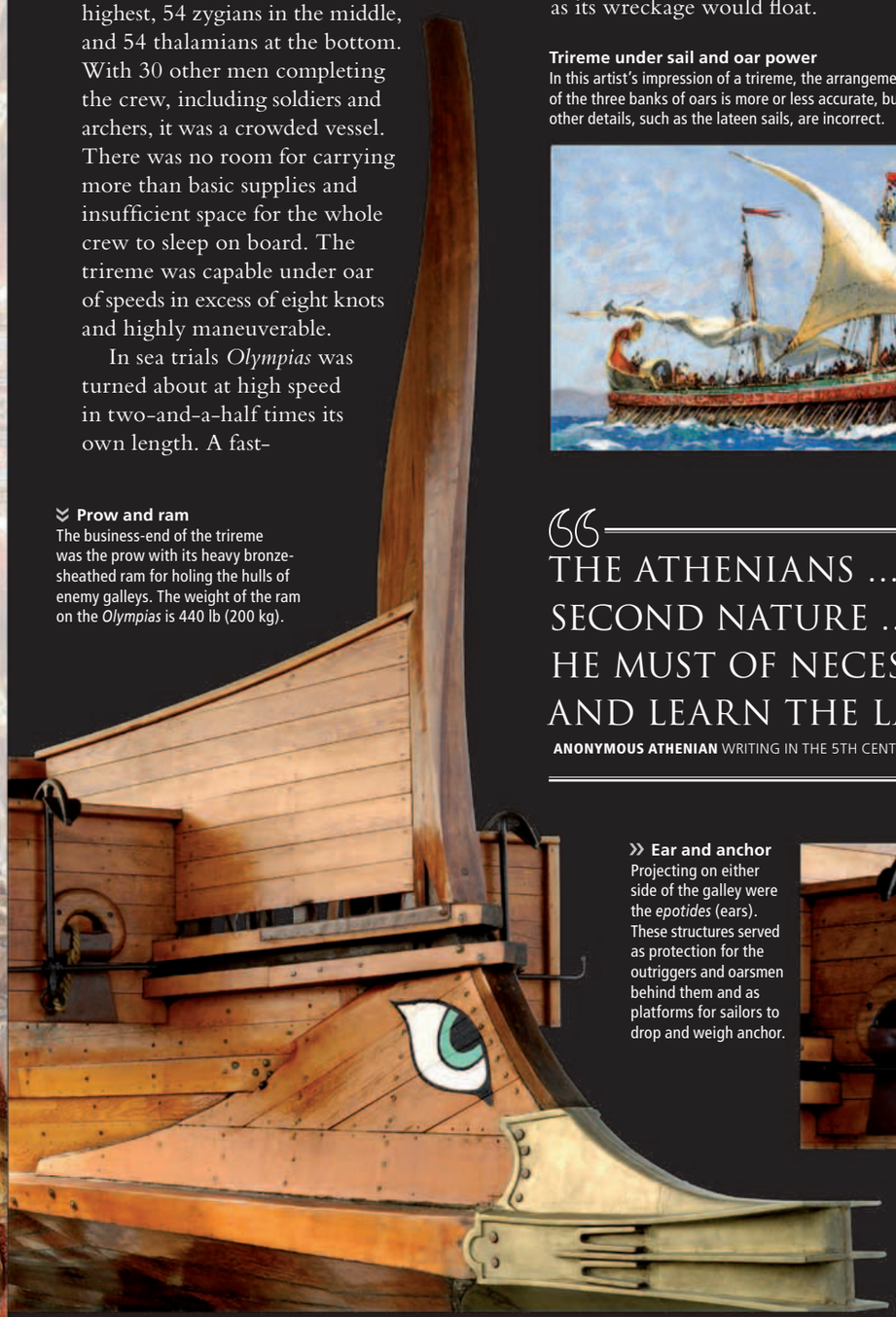
Trireme under sail and oar power
In this artist's impression of a trireme, the arrangement of the three banks of oars is more or less accurate, but other details, such as the lateen sails, are incorrect.





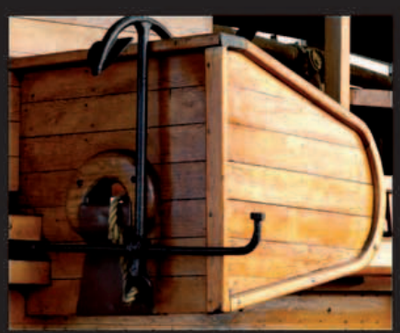
Olympias
The side view of *Olympias* (top) gives an idea of the arrangement of the sails and the three levels of oar ports. The overhead view (bottom) shows the exact location of each individual oarsman's seat. The oarsmen's positions are covered by a protective deck.

» Prow and ram
The business-end of the trireme was the prow with its heavy bronze-sheathed ram for holing the hulls of enemy galleys. The weight of the ram on the *Olympias* is 440 lb (200 kg).



> "THE ATHENIANS ... LEARN TO USE THE OAR AS SECOND NATURE ... WHEN A MAN IS OFTEN AT SEA HE MUST OF NECESSITY TAKE AN OAR HIMSELF ... AND LEARN THE LANGUAGE OF THE SEA."
>
> **ANONYMOUS ATHENIAN** WRITING IN THE 5TH CENTURY BCE

» Ear and anchor
Projecting on either side of the galley were the *epotides* (ears). These structures served as protection for the outriggers and oarsmen behind them and as platforms for sailors to drop and weigh anchor.



» Outrigger
This projection was built out from the sides of the galley, supported by brackets. It allowed the upper tier of oarsmen to row from a position outboard of the other two tiers.

